But the emperor *was* dying and it was only his supreme will that enabled him to engage with his men and his courtiers as he lay on his sickbed. Man Singh in desperation now attempted to seize the treasury of Agra but Ram Das Kachhwaha had posted his Rajput soldiers to defend it, and once again Man Singh was foiled. The raja accepted that he had failed in his mission to secure the throne for Khusrau and prepared his boats to sail away from Agra to Bengal the following morning, along with his nephew.

All this while, Salim had been shut up in his quarters outside the fort, paralysed by fear and uncertainty. He debated the idea of meeting his father, although he was certain that he would be accused of poisoning him. He was enraged by reports of the attempt to place Khusrau on the throne, and suspected everyone around him of treachery and malice. Finally, triumphant news arrived in Salim's quarters of the decision of the nobles. Shaikh Farid soon arrived, along with the Sayyids of Baraha, and many other courtiers to assure the prince of their support. All they asked of Salim, according to possibly suspect reports by the Jesuits, was that he be a true guardian of Islam, and that he not punish his sons or those who had supported them, and this the prince agreed to do. As news spread of this momentous decision, people streamed into Salim's house, eager to align themselves to his ascending star. A crestfallen and abashed Mirza Aziz Koka too appeared, late in the evening, greatly ashamed, but Salim was magnanimous with him now that the Mughal throne was finally within reach. Assured of the safety of his nephew, Man Singh, too, would bring Khusrau back to his father.

The next day, Salim presented himself at last to his dying father. Akbar opened his eyes and gestured for Salim to be given the imperial turban, robes, and dagger. Salim then performed the sijda, prostrating himself on the floor one last time to lay his head at his father's feet. Seeing that his father was quite beyond speech, Salim hustled his son Khurram out of Agra Fort and took him back with him to his own palace.

In the waning day of Tuesday, 26 October, with the premonition of winter in the cooling air, the world shrank around Padshah Akbar. All his great noblemen had died, or had left him, sensing the dawn of a new age. Some had quit brazenly, others had melted quietly away, all of them distancing themselves from the aura of death. It was the turn of Hakim Ali to desert, fearing the wrath of the harem and he hurried to join Shaikh Farid. Akbar's great taswir khanas were still, the artists dispersed. Some